

B H U B A N E S W A R | Changing Colours

The colours of saffron seem to be changing in Orissa. Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik is all set to dump the BJP and script a new secular alliance before the crucial twin Lok Sabha and Assembly elections. He has the support of local Congressmen and the Left, who are ready to join forces with his BJD to oppose the BJP and the Bajrang Dal in Orissa. Also, there are indications that the CPI, NCP and Shibu Soren's Jharkhand Mukti Morcha will rally around him. This fallout apparently stems from Patnaik's meeting with VHP leader Ashok Singhal on September 9 following the mayhem against Christians in Kandhamal. Singhal had reportedly issued the chief minister an ultimatum, "Decide whether you want to be on the side of Hindus and return to power or be politically doomed." An alarmed Patnaik has now made it clear that the BJD will not concede any more seats to the BJP, once its most loyal ally; chances are it may even go to the polls alone. *by Farzand Ahmed*



PATNAIK

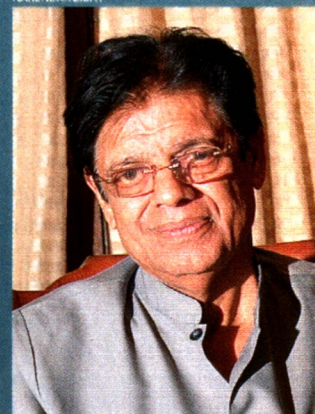
RAVI S. SAMANI



golden pumpkin

AS THE MP from the Muslim-dominated Ponnani constituency in North Kerala where Israel bashing is a thriving cottage industry, E. Ahamed must have had the impending elections in mind when last week he demanded that Delhi sever all ties with Tel Aviv. But as junior minister for external affairs, he should have known better. Israel, of late, has become one of our closest allies and, after Russia, the biggest arms supplier to India. Ahamed's failure to understand such vital and strategic facts in these dangerous times makes one thing clear: he is either short of common sense or he is oblivious to all but his own electoral needs.

NARENDRA BISHT



Left At Home

The global meltdown has taken a toll on the Marxists who are skipping annual pilgrimages to Havana, Caracas and Tuscany and settling for domestic destinations. CPI(M) Politburo member Sitaram Yechury vacationed in scenic Sunderbans during at the year-end.



TEWARI

PATNA | Saint vs Singer

The SP is fielding Bhojpuri star Manoj Tewari from Gorakhpur in the Lok Sabha polls against BJP's Aditya Yogi and BSP's Vinay Shankar Tewari, son of mafia don-turned-politician Hari Shankar Tewari. Manoj is idolised in Gorakhpur, the epicentre of Bhojpuri films. He had taken on MNS chief Raj Thackeray during his anti-north India tirade. Yogi heads the Gorakhdham Mandir Peeth and enjoys a huge following, but is seen as anti-Muslim and anti-Brahmin, which may limit his electoral reach. *by Amitabh Srivastava*



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Blank Slate

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